Friends of Finance

CASE FILE / QUICK-START FIELD GUIDE

THE FINANCE DETECTIVE

Quick-Start Investigation Guide

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Welcome to the Case Room

Five fictional business problems. Real-world style evidence. Your judgment. You will read the brief, open the evidence, form a hypothesis, test alternatives, and then compare your reasoning with the solution.

The goal is not to memorize answers. It is to practice how strong finance professionals separate symptoms from causes.

CASE-001	**The $85,000 Cash Mystery** Cash flow & working capital	15 min
CASE-002	**The Customer Who Stopped Paying** AR & collections	15 min
CASE-003	**The Subscription That Never Died** Spend management	12 min
CASE-004	**Revenue Is Up. Profit Is Down.** FP&A & profitability	18 min
CASE-005	**The Month-End Close That Never Ends** Accounting, controls & operations	15 min

What you will practice

Cash reconciliation / collections prioritization / recurring-spend control / variance decomposition / close bottleneck analysis

How to Investigate

1

Read the brief

Restate the problem in one sentence. What is expected, what happened, and how large is the gap?

2

Inspect the evidence

Open every evidence item (E-01, E-02 ...). Note what each one proves and what it cannot prove. Tick Cite only for items that support your reasoning.

3

Form a hypothesis

Write the suspected cause, the evidence that supports it, an alternative explanation, your confidence and the next verification step.

4

Test alternatives

Ask what else would produce the same numbers. Look for the record that would rule each alternative in or out.

5

Make a recommendation

Pair an immediate fix with a preventive control and a measure that shows whether it worked.

6

Reveal and compare

Reveal only when ready. Compare your reasoning with the reconciliation, not just your final answer.

Evidence verification habit

Distinguish confirmed facts (a bank credit, a timestamp) from claims and hypotheses (an opinion, an assumption). Only facts can close a case.

Scoring and Best Practices

Dimension	Points	How it is scored
Evidence selection and relevance	25	Your first-step choice plus citing the relevant evidence. Citing irrelevant items subtracts.
Testing alternative explanations	25	How well you tested what else could explain the numbers.
Evidence-backed diagnosis	30	24 for the diagnosis you chose; 6 from a keyword check of your written hypothesis.
Practical corrective action	20	Quality of your fix, control and measure.

Each case totals 100 points. Partial credit is given for defensible approaches. Learning labels (Pattern Spotter, Evidence Analyst, Root-Cause Investigator, Finance Strategist) are playful and are not a professional assessment or certification.

Best practices

- Let the evidence lead. Write down what the numbers show before you say why.
- Reconcile to zero. A solved case leaves no unexplained residual.
- Ask what would prove you wrong, then look for that record.
- Communicate the finding in one executive sentence with the number attached.

Common mistakes

- Jumping to conclusions: picking the first plausible cause (for example, assuming an overdue invoice means a credit problem).
- Confusing correlation with causation: two things moving together does not make one the cause of the other.
- Treating a symptom as the cause: a late close or a margin percentage is where you start, not where you stop.

All companies, people and figures are fictional learning scenarios created for this exercise. Progress on the website is stored only in your browser.

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Reusable Investigation Notes

Case: _____ Date: _____

FINANCIAL ANOMALY

SUSPECTED ROOT CAUSE

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE REFERENCES (E-01, E-02 ...)

ALTERNATIVE EXPLANATIONS

NEXT VERIFICATION STEP

CORRECTIVE ACTION

PREVENTIVE CONTROL

SUCCESS METRIC